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Inter Milan and Barcelona produced an **instant classic**, battling to a thrilling draw in the first leg of their semifinal showdown.

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Football, Bloody Hell!’ — Sir Alex Ferguson’s adrenaline-fuelled remark spoke volumes about the tensions surrounding UEFA Champions League (UCL) clashes. This was the final of 1999, between Manchester United and Bayern Munich.

Two decades later, the competition continues to give goosebumps. The first leg of the semifinal clash between Barcelona and Inter Milan, which previously had Pep Guardiola and Jose Mourinho as the poster boys of an iconic rivalry, turned out to be a blockbuster affair.

Inter scored within a minute, then doubled the lead before Barcelona pulled one back, going on to equalise within the first half. Inter retook the lead before Barca restored parity again at 3-3. At the final whistle, players and fans alike ran out of breath.

Only four semifinals in the European Cup/Champions League before this had seen three or more goals scored by each team.

Two players stole the spotlight in the match — one named after a Hollywood icon, Denzel Washington (Denzel Dumfries), and the other

‘baptised’ by Lionel Messi (Lamine Yamal).

Inter’s Dumfries scored twice and assisted another, while Yamal **(above)** ran rings around the Inter defence, scoring once, creating two chances and taking six shots — one fewer than the entire Italian club.

With the goal, the 17-year-old Yamal became the youngest goalscorer in a UCL semifinal, breaking the record of Kylian Mbappe. Dumfries, meanwhile, became the first Dutch player to hit a brace in a UCL semifinal.

“Yamal is clearly a talent of the type born every 50 years. Talents like this I’ve never really seen before,” Inter manager Simone Inzaghi said after the match.

In the other semifinal, Paris